

What Is Consciousness?

Consciousness is our awareness of external stimuli (such as our surroundings) and internal events (such as our thoughts and feelings). We can identify the brain activity that generates conscious awareness, but how this phenomenon arises from a physical organ remains a mystery.

Locating consciousness

Our thoughts, feelings, and ideas are all activities of the brain—products with a neurological basis. However, it is unclear whether it is the neurological activity itself that forms consciousness (or the “mind”) or whether it is merely linked to consciousness. This is the fundamental difference between two theories of consciousness. The first, monism, equates the mind with the brain, while the second, dualism, sees the mind as separate from the brain and body.

Monism

According to monism, every thought, feeling, and idea is a product of the brain activity that occurs as the result of a stimulus. This brain activity is itself the conscious perception of the object. In other words, the brain is the mind and vice versa.



MONISM

DUALISM

Where is the mind?

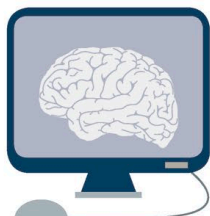
When we see an object, it is the result of our brain perceiving a light stimulus. However, whether this activity in our brain directly leads to consciousness, or whether the activity links to an external mind, is debated.



LIGHT

VIRTUAL REALITY

Virtual and augmented realities are no longer restricted to the plots of science fiction. Computers are now used to simulate external stimuli—such as sights or sounds—that provide the brain with an alternative reality.



BRAIN STEM DEATH

In some parts of the world, the legal definition of death is brain stem death. Irreversible damage to the brain stem (see p.36) prevents it from regulating the automatic functions essential to life. These may be continued with the help of medical equipment, but the person will never regain consciousness.

